

## US Tariff Impact Tracker: Import Outlook Remains Positive to End May Lapping Liberation Day

**US Tariff Impact Tracker:** This past week, laden vessels from China to USA were down sequentially (-3% WoW) and accelerated on a YoY basis (+23% YoY). Data suggests TEUs coming into Port of LA will turn positive next week (+14% WoW) following this past week's -15% sequential, before seeing an increase of +3% WoW two weeks out (YoY is expected to be +6% and +63% one week and two weeks out). What we will need to monitor is how levels move through May and June, which could suggest how shippers are deciding to restock with in some cases lower effective tariff rates amidst an uncertain geopolitical backdrop—so far, there appears to be strong restocking in addition to lapping Liberation Day, given the double-digit YoY import trajectory.

**Trade uncertainty remains prevalent in global trade, especially following the recent Supreme Court ruling and the subsequent announcement from the administration for new tariffs under Sec. 122 (see our macro team's [assessment](#)).** We believe that the uncertainty may have two near- to medium-term impacts on global freight. First, given that trade uncertainty has risen and the administration has not disclosed how it will proceed after the Sec. 122 tariffs expire in 150 days, this may impact medium- to longer-term freight planning. Second, a more near-term impact will be countries that now have a lower effective tariff rate may pick up exports into the U.S. We note that this may take time to show up in the data, particularly for freight out of mainland China as manufacturing and shipping pick back up following a later than usual LNY.

**We do note that the ongoing geopolitical conflicts could impact ocean and air rates higher, but we need to disassociate the driver of rate increases from capacity constraints and surcharges versus import demand and the impact of tariffs.** Impacts on ocean trade could be limited given the low-single-digit capacity in the Gulf; however, we do note there could be a rise on rates globally and Asia to U.S. in part as ocean carriers try to pass on fuel costs, specifically bunker fuel costs. The larger impact to keep in mind is how higher energy costs could impact overall global demand for freight and in particular for the American consumer, with greater impact depending on the duration of the conflict.

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**Key observations from this past week's report:**

- **China freight flows (week ending Thursday, May 21st) showed a sequential decline in laden vessels from China to the US (-3%) with a positive YoY at +23% (vs +11% in the prior week).**
- **Port Optimizer sequentials indicate imports into the Port of Los Angeles are set to be up +14% TEUs (May 29) while the early read suggests an increase of +3% on a two-week out basis;** on a YoY basis, imports into LA are set to remain strongly positive to 6% and 63%—likely from easy Liberation Day comps.
- **Rail intermodal volumes along the West Coast were +9% YoY following last week's +4% performance.**
- **Ocean container rates were up +13% sequentially after declining -0.5% last week; rates on a YoY basis were +14% YoY this past week.** We anticipate some choppiness could emerge over the coming weeks as global capacity shifts given ongoing geopolitical events; however, according to our European counterpart ([see note](#)), the current crisis is not likely to be a positive for container shipping rates—the Strait of Hormuz is not a material artery for liner networks and therefore unlikely to impact the supply side in the way the Red Sea crisis had—however, it is important to note that fuel is likely to drive prices higher.
- **Load availability for trucks on the West Coast increased last week sequentially (+25%) and was positive on a YoY basis (+41%); truck spot rates on the West Coast were up +30% YoY ex-fuel.**

**What the Tracker Is:**

**What We Disseminate Weekly: High frequency data to help assess the ongoing impact of tariffs on global supply chains and the accompanying ramifications on the flows of freight (e.g., expected ships leaving from China to USA).** While we think our data set is representative, we do plan to periodically add new data series as they become available.

**It is important to recognize that weekly data can be volatile, with a fair bit of noise depending on timing—but we still think looking at the data collectively, and perhaps over a multi-week basis can be informative as to tariff-related trends.**

**2026 Trade and Transport Scenario Roadmap — Revised From First and Second Edition:**

As we moved past the 2025 homestretch and into 2026, the ability to find a profit and earnings bottom and eventually see an earnings upgrade cycle comes down to one thing: volume growth, with an appropriate weighting towards higher margin business-to-business, commercial and/or manufacturing flows. Recent improved share price performance from the trucking sector could perhaps be tied to the notion that volumes (and in terms of truckload - supply) could indeed be at a more stable point with which improvement could come from at some point in 2026.

**Ramifications from tariff-related uncertainty that caused pull-forward in demand—bracketed by shipper indecision as to how much product to manufacture and/or order for inventory—had been a culprit behind transports broad**

**underperformance for much of 2025 and tied directly into our view that we may see subseasonal peak season shipping demand (for 4Q reporting).**

That said, we remain positive on the cycle recovery story—despite the heretofore elusive bottom, and we note several factors that could finally stimulate a favorable and fulsome volume inflection into 2026 as we look to the medium to longer term.

- Fed rate cut cycles are typically beneficial to transport shares (see [Fed Rate Cuts and Transports](#)); GS economists continue to predict 2 more rate cuts in 2026 to add to the three cuts in 2025.
- While tariff uncertainty still exists, we will lap Liberation Day on April 2, 2026—potentially yielding a more consistent playbook for shippers to work with and to plan.
- Various corporations are announcing increased investments in US manufacturing—including companies like Apple, Nvidia, IBM, Pfizer, Johnson & Johnson, etc.—which should auger-in more domestic freight flows.
- The bonus depreciation revival via the *One Big Beautiful Bill Act* could incentivize capital to reinvest in businesses.
- While tariff deployment is disruptive, any resulting re-shoring or nearshoring would bolster US manufacturing, which also should auger-in more domestic freight flows.
- Shifting logistics patterns and changing supply chain sourcing could drive secular global trade opportunity as companies potentially pursue a China Plus 1 or 2 strategy.

**What to do with Transport stocks:**

- For the time being we note that the volatile nature and potential air pocket in 2H25 will likely impact all transports as we end 2025 if consumer demand does not lift shipments post pull-forward. We did however upgrade the truckers (see [our upgrade note](#)), as we think the likelihood of recession has lessened, and the consumer can stay relatively resilient (GS economists [lowered](#) their recession forecast to 30% earlier this summer and their GDP outlook in the 4Q26 is +2.2% YoY). While freight forwarders such as EXPD and CHRW could benefit from the volatility and surge in customs brokerage demand, we do note that YoY comparisons for ocean rates will be challenging, as we have seen ocean container rates turn sharply negative on a YoY basis. Should the Red Sea re-open, that could further add to effective capacity.
- **Other beneficiaries could be the parcels (UPS and FDX—both Buy rated) with their fast cycle logistics and air freight as well as large global footprints that can help shippers shift supply chains.**

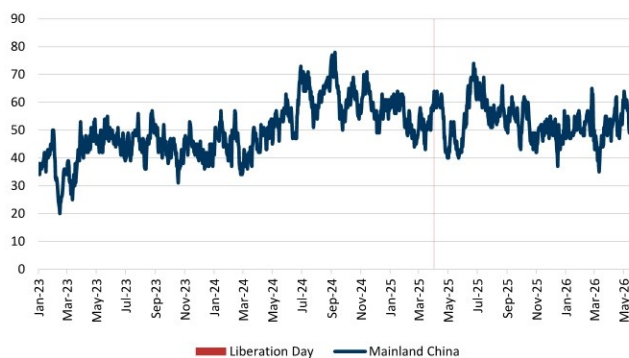
## High Frequency Weekly Data

We track weekly (and some daily) data that helps provide as real time as possible insights into trade volumes, demand and pricing. We note that much of this data is choppy in the near term and more than often shows trends developing over time as we

receive more data, but also speaks to the volatility of trade flows. Therefore, we caution against drawing conclusions week to week but note that it can be helpful to see changes in the data week to week given the dynamic trade environment. Below, we track the high frequency data points that we believe are highly relevant to trade and US freight transportation.

- **Laden container vessels from China to the US were +23% YoY over the last week (5/15-5/21) versus +11% YoY in the prior week (5/8-5/14). The sequential vessel decrease of -3% in the most recent week follows last week's decrease of -9%.**

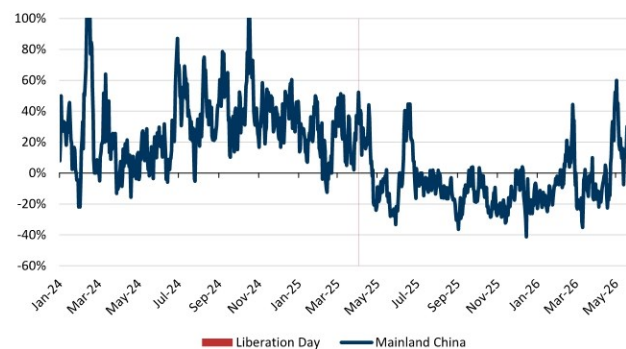
**Exhibit 1: Container ships to the US remain volatile; levels are still down from post-Liberation day increases**  
Daily Laden Container Ship Vessels from China to US



Data through 5/21/26 Captures the number of laden (i.e., cargo-carrying) container ships departing China en route to the US over a rolling 15-day window. Includes only vessels confirmed to be transporting cargo. Laden vessels are those reporting a draft of more than 75% of maximum draft at the start of their journey to the US. Note that data is subject to revisions.

Source: Bloomberg

**Exhibit 2: Laden container ships from China to US have improved on a YoY basis in the most recent week**  
Daily Laden Container Ship Vessels from China to US, YoY



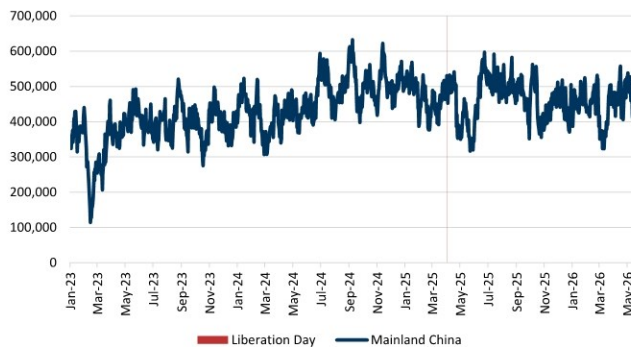
Data through 5/21/26 captures the number of laden (i.e., cargo-carrying) container ships departing China en route to the US over a rolling 15-day window. Includes only vessels confirmed to be transporting cargo. Laden vessels are those reporting a draft of more than 75% of maximum draft at the start of their journey to the US. Note that data is subject to revisions.

Source: Bloomberg

- **TEUs from China to the US were +26.5% YoY over the past week (5/15-5/21) versus +4% in the prior week (5/8-5/14). Sequentially, we saw a +4% change in TEUs from Mainland China.**

**Exhibit 3: TEUs have remained volatile**

Daily TEU from China to the US

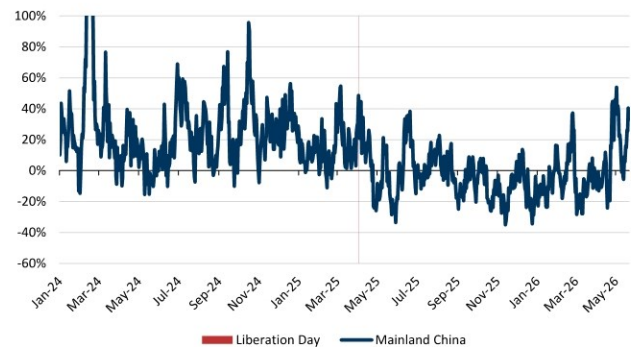


Data as of 5/21/2026. Represents the aggregated container volume, measured in twenty-foot equivalent units (TEU), of vessels departing China for the United States over a 15-day rolling period. Accounts for the shipping capacity being utilized, irrespective of the number of vessels. Dry cargo vessels leaving China are monitored as they exit Chinese waters. The dataset is filtered for vessels that have left over the 15 previous days and have reported the US as their country of destination. Note that data is subject to revisions.

Source: Bloomberg

**Exhibit 4: TEU growth was up in the most recent week**

Daily TEU from China to the US, YoY



Data as of 5/21/2026. Represents the aggregated container volume, measured in twenty-foot equivalent units (TEU), of vessels departing China for the United States over a 15-day rolling period. Accounts for the shipping capacity being utilized, irrespective of the number of vessels. Dry cargo vessels leaving China are monitored as they exit Chinese waters. The dataset is filtered for vessels that have left over the 15 previous days and have reported the US as their country of destination. Note that data is subject to revisions.

Source: Bloomberg

**Exhibit 5: Week 20 China to US vessels were down while TEUs were up WoW**

Weekly Average TEUs and Vessels from China to US

| Bloomberg China to US 6 Week Dashboard Weekly Average TEUs & Vessels |         |         |         |         |         |         |         |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|---------|---------|---------|---------|---------|---------|---------|
| Week                                                                 | 14      | 15      | 16      | 17      | 18      | 19      | 20      |
| 2026 Vessels                                                         | 51      | 57      | 49      | 56      | 61      | 55      | 54      |
| WoW                                                                  |         | 12.0%   | -13.9%  | 12.4%   | 9.0%    | -8.7%   | -3.1%   |
| 2025 Vessels                                                         | 60      | 60      | 55      | 42      | 46      | 50      | 44      |
| 2025 WoW                                                             |         | -0.9%   | -8.6%   | -23.6%  | 10.6%   | 8.0%    | -12.6%  |
| 2026 YoY                                                             | -14.9%  | -3.8%   | -9.4%   | 33.2%   | 31.3%   | 10.9%   | 23.0%   |
| 2026 TEUs                                                            | 461,271 | 504,128 | 437,736 | 504,355 | 514,918 | 457,469 | 473,908 |
| WoW                                                                  |         | 9.3%    | -13.2%  | 15.2%   | 2.1%    | -11.2%  | 3.6%    |
| 2025 TEUs                                                            | 495,552 | 500,552 | 479,555 | 366,182 | 384,265 | 440,938 | 374,691 |
| 2025 WoW                                                             |         | 1.0%    | -4.2%   | -23.6%  | 4.9%    | 14.7%   | -15.0%  |
| 2026 YoY                                                             | -6.9%   | 0.7%    | -8.7%   | 37.7%   | 34.0%   | 3.7%    | 26.5%   |

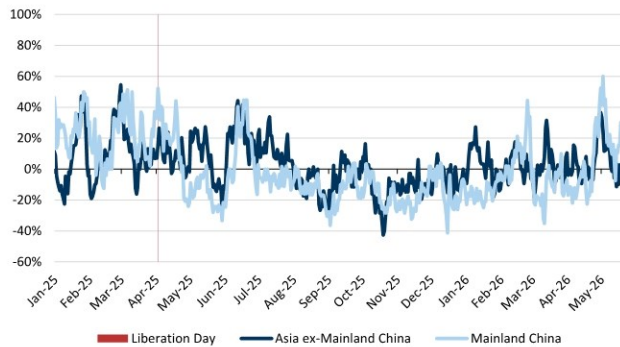
Week 20 5/15/2026-5/21/2026; Note that data is subject to revisions.

Source: Bloomberg

**Mainland China's laden vessel and TEU growth vs. Asia Ex-Mainland China to US: On a laden vessel basis, Mainland China was up +21% YoY on average while Asia-Ex Mainland China was flat. On a TEU basis, Mainland China was up +23% YoY on average while Asia-Ex Mainland was up 6% on average.** We use the summation of Mainland China, Vietnam, South Korea, Taiwan and Japan as a proxy for Asia exports to the US.

**Exhibit 6: Mainland China and Asia-Ex Mainland: vessels were up YoY for Mainland China v. Asia Ex Mainland China up YoY**

Daily Laden Container Ship Vessels from Asia ex-Mainland China and Mainland China to US, YoY

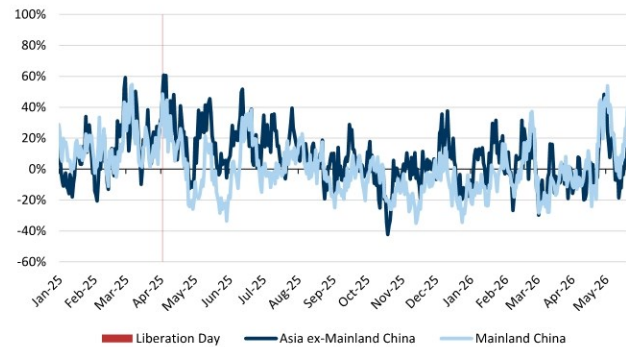


Asia ex-Mainland China includes Vietnam, South Korea, Taiwan, and Japan Data as of 5/21/2026

Source: Bloomberg

**Exhibit 7: TEU growth from Mainland China was up vs Asia-Ex Mainland China was down this past week**

Daily TEU from Asia ex-Mainland China and Mainland China to US, YoY



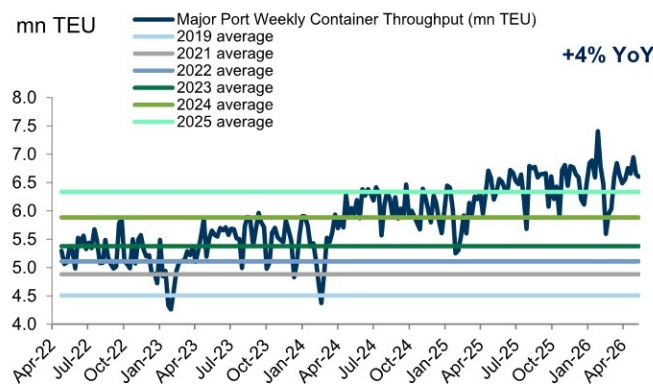
Asia ex-Mainland China includes Vietnam, South Korea, Taiwan and Japan Data as of 5/21/2026

Source: Bloomberg

- Chinese major port weekly throughput was -1% w/w during the week ended 5/17 (latest available) after being -4% w/w the prior week. **Throughput was +4% YoY vs +7% in the prior week.**

**Exhibit 8: Chinese port activity was down -1% sequentially in the most recent week and up 4% YoY**

Chinese major port weekly container throughput



Note: Label showing latest weekly YoY showing data from 11-May-2026 to 17-May-2026

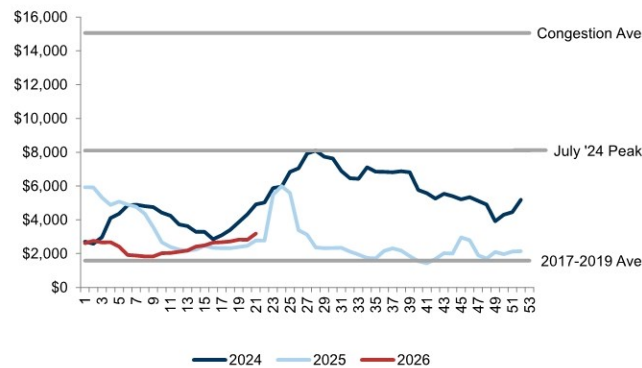
Weekly through 5/17/2026. Data compiled by our Asia Analysts, Herbert Lu, Simon Cheung and Dorothy Wong

Source: Ministry of Transport

- Ocean container rates from China/East Asia to the US West Coast were up +13% W/W and +14% YoY in the most recent week – the last month’s growth represents the first positive YoY growth period since last June, partly reflecting easier comps and sequential uplifts. We anticipate some volatility over the coming weeks as global capacity shifts given ongoing geopolitical events.

**Exhibit 9: Ocean rates were up 13% WoW after -0.5% in the previous week**

China/East Asia to the North American West Coast, \$/FEU



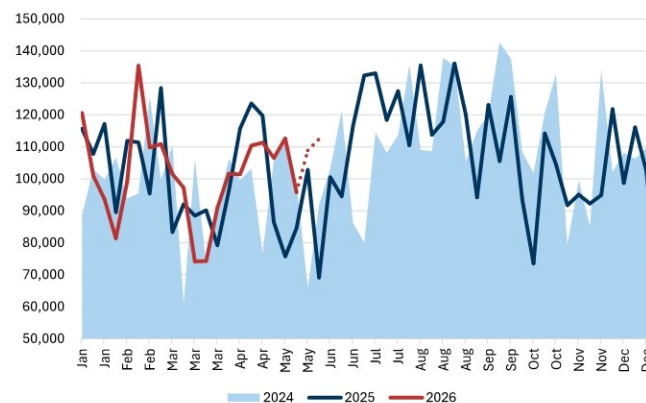
Weekly rate through 5/22/2026

Source: Freightos

- **Planned TEUs into the Port of LA in the most recent week was down -15% sequentially after -4%/+6% WoW moves in the prior two weeks. Looking ahead, this week’s negative sequential appears to increase next week to +14% before increasing +3% two-weeks out. YoY trends are expected to stay positive for TEUs up +6% YoY next week and +63% two weeks out.**

**Exhibit 10: Planned TEUs are expected to increase sequentially next week and 2 weeks out**

Planned TEUs into the Port of LA



Weekly data updated daily as of 5/22/2026 Port Optimizer data includes two week forward data for week ending 6/5

Source: Port Optimizer

**Exhibit 11: Tracking volumes over the last four weeks and upcoming 2 weeks**

## Port Optimizer 6 Week Dashboard

| Port Optimizer 6 Week Dashboard |           |          |          |           |           |           |          |
|---------------------------------|-----------|----------|----------|-----------|-----------|-----------|----------|
| Date                            | 4/24/2026 | 5/1/2026 | 5/8/2026 | 5/15/2026 | 5/22/2026 | 5/29/2026 | 6/5/2026 |
| Week                            | 16        | 17       | 18       | 19        | 20        | 21        | 22       |
| TEUs                            | 110,401   | 111,337  | 106,533  | 112,656   | 95,830    | 108,881   | 112,490  |
| WoW                             | N/A       | 0.8%     | -4.3%    | 5.7%      | -14.9%    | 13.6%     | 3.3%     |
| 2025 WoW                        | 6.8%      | -3.1%    | -27.8%   | -12.4%    | 11.8%     | 21.6%     | -32.9%   |
| 2026 YoY                        | -10.7%    | -7.1%    | 23.2%    | 48.8%     | 13.3%     | 5.8%      | 62.9%    |
| Vessels                         | 19        | 19       | 19       | 20        | 18        | 19        | 21       |
| WoW                             | N/A       | 0.0%     | 0.0%     | 5.3%      | -10.0%    | 5.6%      | 10.5%    |
| 2025 WoW                        | 14.3%     | -8.3%    | -27.3%   | 0.0%      | 18.8%     | 10.5%     | -23.8%   |
| 2026 YoY                        | -20.8%    | -13.6%   | 18.8%    | 25.0%     | -5.3%     | -9.5%     | 31.3%    |

Weekly data update as of 5/22/2026 Port Optimizer data includes two week forward data for week ending 6/5

Source: Port Optimizer

- WorldACD Weekly Cargo Trends Asia Pacific to North America weights and rates (as of 5/14; latest), two week over two week was -6% and +3% last week, after +2% and +4% in the prior week, respectively. The sequential increase in rate is likely from the increase in higher jet fuel pricing. The sequential weight movements are figures to watch to ascertain the need for faster cycle logistics. **We continue to monitor rate impact on global and regional rates from reduced air capacity in Gulf states in addition to increase in jet fuel pricing, noting the limited visibility on weekly rates, as well as recognizing the dynamic situation as some airports have limited reopening of flights.**

**Exhibit 12: Trends for air cargo out of Asia Pacific to North America: weight decreased in the most recent week (-6%) and rate increased (+3%)**

WorldACD Last Two Weeks Compared with the Preceding Two Weeks, Asia Pacific to North America Weight and Rate



Weekly two week over two week change as of 5/14/2026

Source: WorldACD

- Intermodal traffic growth on the West Coast (UNP/BNSF) was +9% YoY in the most recent week, versus +4% last week.

**Exhibit 13: West Coast intermodal carloads were +9% YoY versus +4% YoY last week**  
Intermodal Carloads on the West Coast

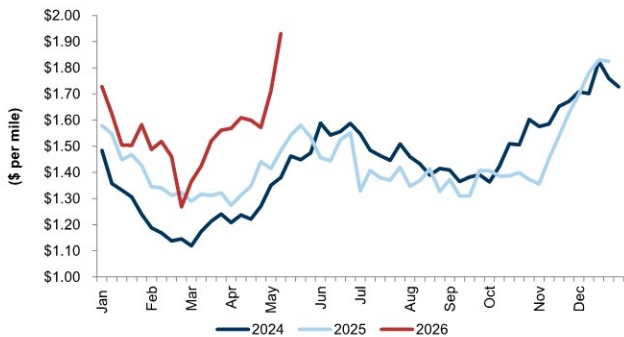


Weekly intermodal carload as of 5/16/2026

Source: AAR

- Truckload spot rates ex-fuel on the West Coast from truckstop.com were up +13% w/w and +30% YoY in the most recent week.
- Truck load availability index on the West Coast was up +25% w/w and up +41% YoY.

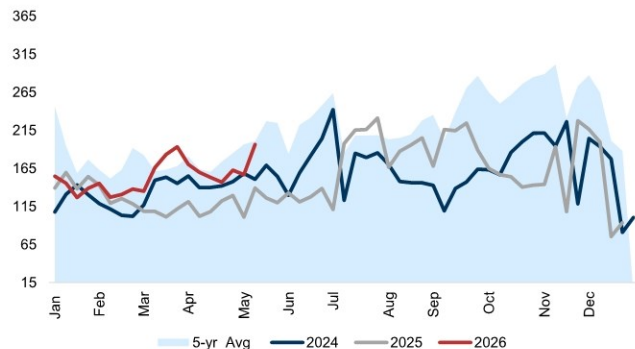
**Exhibit 14: Rates were +30% YoY last week on the West Coast**  
Truckload Spot Rates ex-fuel West Coast



Weekly data as of 5/18/2026

Source: Truckstop.com

**Exhibit 15: Truckload load availability was +41% YoY this past week on the West Coast**  
Truckload Load Availability Index on the West Coast



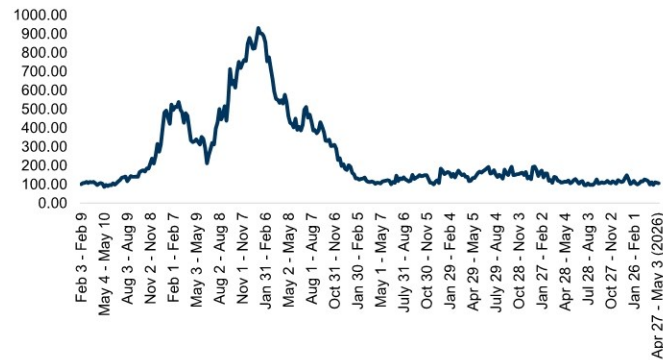
Weekly data as of 5/18/2026

Source: Truckstop.com

- Our Supply Chain Congestion Tracker stayed at '2' this past week as the bottleneck index was decreased -2% w/w; overall fluidity levels are closer to the pre-Covid baseline.

**Exhibit 16: Congestion remains fluid as per our supply chain congestion index, about in line with pre-Covid levels**

GS Weekly Supply Chain Congestion Index, Feb 2020 – May 2026



Weekly data as of 5/10/2026

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

## Lagged Monthly Data

We include monthly data that we believe reflects the impact to freight flows from trade policy.

- Big Three (Ports of LA, Long Beach and Oakland) volumes were -2% YoY and down -3.5% sequentially from February to March—below typical seasonality of +3%.
  - Looking at March from the average of January and February, volumes were down -4% v. usually -2%.

**Exhibit 17: Volumes into the West Coast were down -3.5% in March from February, below historical seasonality**

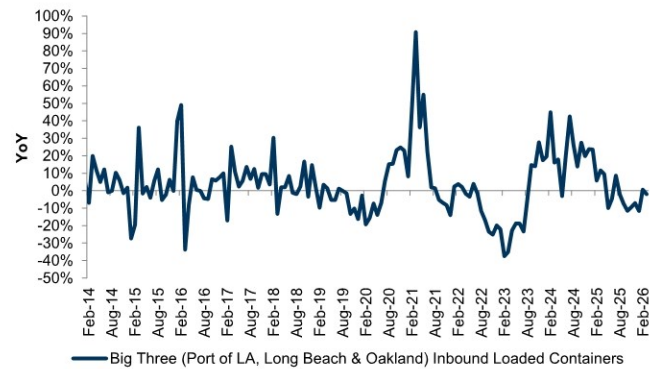
Big Three Volumes

| Mar-2025               | YoY%         | Seq%         | M v. J/F Avg | 5-yr YoY% Avg | 5-yr Seq% Avg | 5-yr Pre-Covid M v. J/F Avg |
|------------------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|---------------|---------------|-----------------------------|
| Port of Long Beach     | -1.6%        | 1.7%         | -3.7%        | 5.5%          | -3.0%         | -5.1%                       |
| Port of LA             | -1.2%        | -12.2%       | -11.0%       | 2.3%          | 5.2%          | -1.6%                       |
| Port of Oakland        | -6.8%        | 24.9%        | 2.0%         | 7.4%          | 21.6%         | 12.8%                       |
| <b>Big Three Total</b> | <b>-2.0%</b> | <b>-3.5%</b> | <b>-3.7%</b> | <b>3.5%</b>   | <b>3.2%</b>   | <b>-1.8%</b>                |

Source: Port of Los Angeles, Port of Long Beach, Port of Oakland

### Exhibit 18: Imports into the West Coast were -2% YoY in March

Big Three Volumes YoY

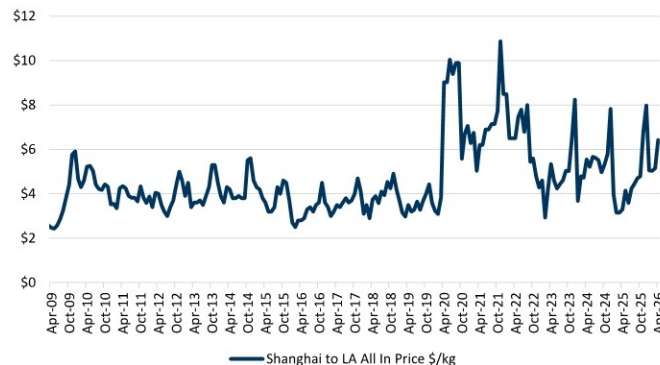


Source: Port of Los Angeles, Port of Long Beach, Port of Oakland

- Drewry air rates from Shanghai to LA were up +25% MoM in April after being +2% in March. Depending on the development of geopolitical events, we could see a continued increase of rates in May as air capacity gets tied up in addition to the rise in jet fuel prices—to be determined.

### Exhibit 19: April rates were up 25% from March

Drewry Air Rates Shanghai to LA

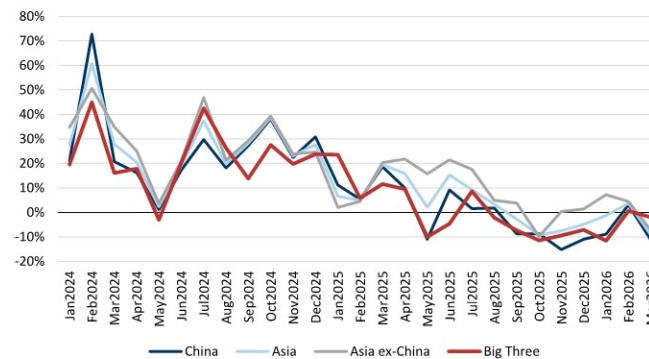


Source: Drewry

- **Big Three YoY v. Monthly YoY growth of Bloomberg reported TEUs from China, Asia and Asia ex-China to US shows a strong relationship.**

**Exhibit 20: Big Three growth tends to follow TEU growth out of Asia to the US**

Big Three YoY v. China/Asia/Asia ex-China to US TEU Monthly YoY

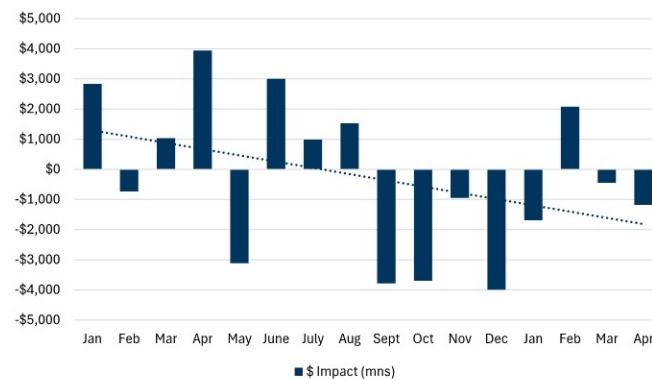


China and Asia TEU YoY data through 2/26

Source: Bloomberg, Port of Los Angeles, Port of Long Beach, Port of Oakland

- **We estimate that imports could have been down **-\$1.2bn YoY in April** following March's estimated slight YoY decrease of **~\$0.5bn (Exhibit 21)**. This follows the prior month declines September through January. The higher YoY February may be in part from a later than normal LNY.**
  - We leverage a similar analysis from the Longshoreman strike last October (see our [longshoreman impact note](#)). According to the Bureau of Transportation Statistics, Ocean trade was about \$2.3tn in trade in 2022. The top 25 ports in the U.S. moved 44mn loaded TEUs in 2022, meaning that each loaded container (TEU) on average in 2022 had a value of ~\$52,000. Growing this by inflation of ~3% for the last three years implied value per container of ~\$57,000. Multiplying the YoY change in TEUs with the value/TEU, we estimate the monthly imported value change YoY.

**Exhibit 21: We estimate that April levels were lower YoY**  
Implied Trade Value Change YoY Based on YoY TEU Change and  
Estimated Value/TEU



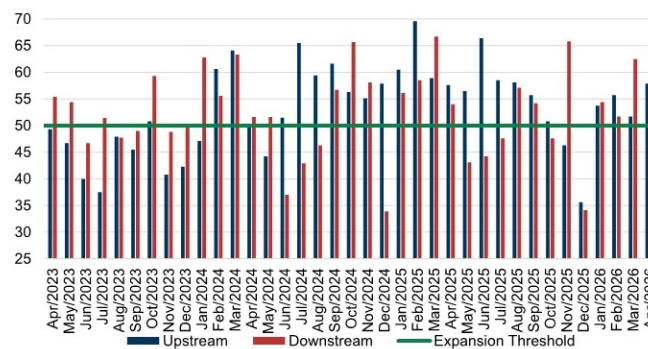
Source: Port Optimizer, US Bureau of Transportation Statistics (BTS), Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

■ Logistics Managers Index Inventory Level Expansion

- ☐ April upstream (B2B) inventories expanded at 57.9 vs 51.7 in March.
- ☐ April downstream (Retail) inventories expanded slower at 53.3 after 62.5 in March.

**Exhibit 22: LMI has shown upstream and downstream expansion**

Logistics Manager Index – Inventory Level Expansion, Upstream (B2B) vs Downstream (Retail) Respondents



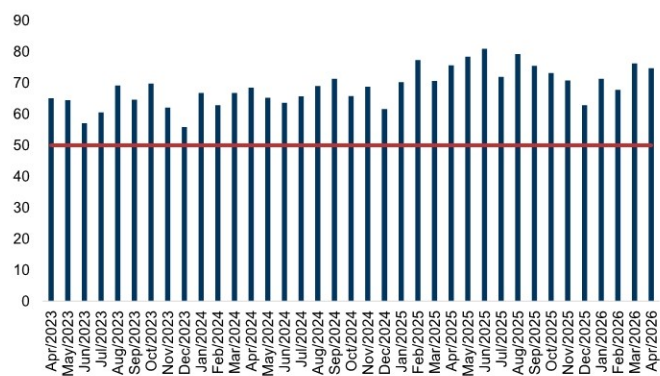
Source: Logistics Managers Index

■ Logistics Managers Index Inventory Cost Index

- ☐ Inventory cost index was 74.7 in April vs 76.2 in March, reflecting still expanding inventory costs.

Exhibit 23: Inventory costs slowed in April

LMI Inventory Cost Index

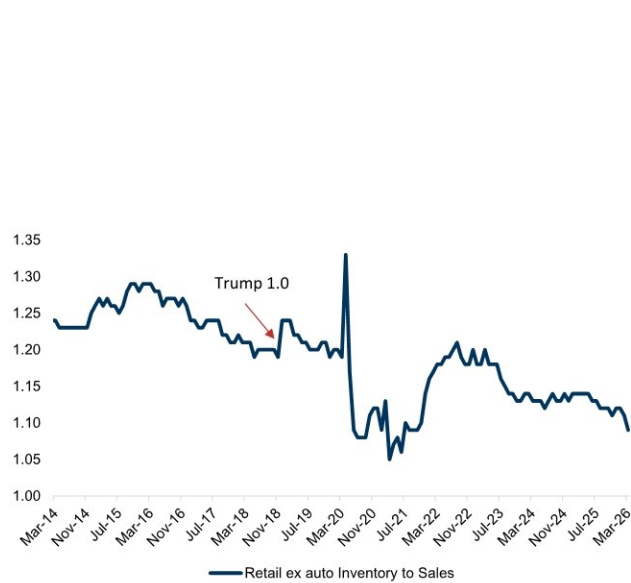


Source: Logistics Managers Index

- Inventory to sales for retailers/manufacturers/wholesalers were 1.09/1.51/1.21 for March which is lower versus February at 1.11/1.52/1.23.

Exhibit 24: Inventory to sales have not shown an increase like in Trump 1.0...

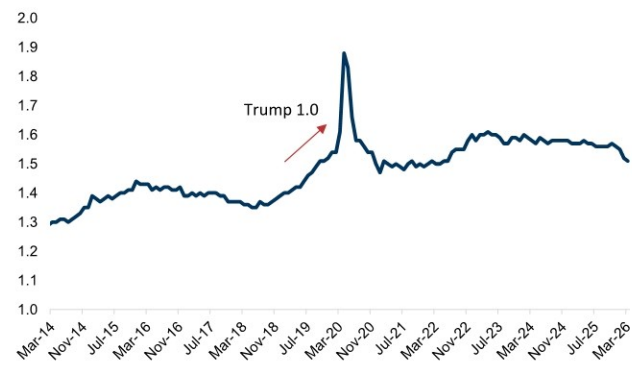
Inventory to Sales Ratio: Retailers ex Motor Vehicle and Parts Dealers



Source: Census Bureau

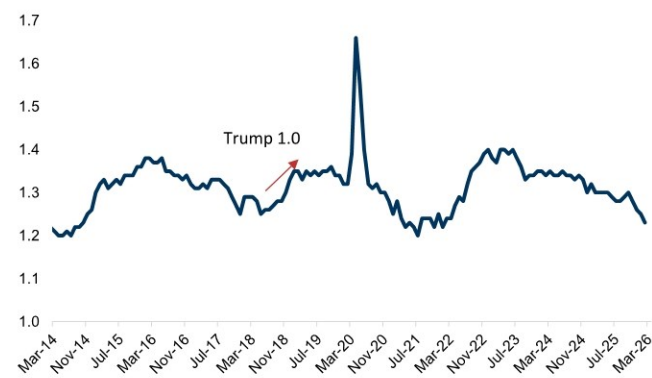
Exhibit 25: ...nor for manufacturers...

Inventory to Sales Manufacturers



Source: Census Bureau

**Exhibit 26: ...while wholesalers were also unchanged**  
Inventory to Sales Wholesalers



Source: Census Bureau

## Disclosure Appendix

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